Demo Version of the Second-Round Tasks

# Russian Language and Culture: Second-Round Sample Tasks for the Open Doors Master's and Doctoral Tracks

This sample test includes 46 tasks: 25 basic-level test tasks with one correct answer, 15 intermediate-level tasks with several correct answers or a model answer, 3 advanced-level tasks requiring a detailed answer, and 3 oral-response tasks. For tasks requiring a detailed answer and for oral-response tasks, assessment criteria and model answers are provided.

## Task 1

**Basic level (maximum 1 point)**

**Field of science:** Russian Language Studies and other languages in Russia

Which phonological school did Ruben Ivanovich Avanesov represent?

**a)** Leningrad (St. Petersburg)

**b)** Copenhagen

**c)** Moscow

**d)** Prague

**Answer: c**

## Task 2

**Basic level (maximum 1 point)**

**Field of science:** Russian Language Studies and other languages in Russia

Which two words are synonyms?

**a)** to speak and to be silent

**b)** beginning and end

**c)** dog and cat

**d)** red and scarlet

**Answer: d**

## Task 3

**Basic level (maximum 1 point)**

**Field of science:** Russian Language Studies and other languages in Russia

A group of syllables united by a single stress and forming a single semantic unit is called…

**a)** a syntagma

**b)** a text

**c)** a speech tact (tact)

**d)** a phonetic word

**Answer: d**

## Task 4

**Basic level (maximum 1 point)**

**Field of science:** Russian Language Studies and other languages in Russia

Such linguistic units as “a house”, “a table”, “a window”, “sea” represent …

**a)** vocabulary associated with a particular functional style.

**b)** neutral vocabulary.

**c)** evocative vocabulary.

**d)** evocative and slightly derogatory vocabulary.

**Answer: b**

## Task 5

**Basic level (maximum 1 point)**

**Field of science:** Russian Language Studies and other languages in Russia

Practical stylistics is an applied normative discipline aimed at ...

**a)** characterizing existing stylistic devices.

**b)** characterizing semantic and functional shades of word meanings.

**c)** promoting the implementation of principles of theoretical stylistics through training and publishing.

**d)** investigating the systematic nature of functional styles.

**Answer: c**

## Task 6

**Basic level (maximum 1 point)**

**Field of science:** Language & linguistics, comparative studies

Which of the following characteristics applies to paradigmatic relations in language?

**a)** elements being combined sequentially

**b)** a class of similar elements that have a linear order

**c)** a system of choice between alternative elements

**d)** the sequence of elements in a chain

**Answer: c**

## Task 7

**Basic level (maximum 1 point)**

**Field of science:** Language & linguistics, comparative studies

What does the concept of linguistic norm refer to?

**a)** the arbitrary use of words by a person.

**b)** traditionally accepted rules of language use.

**c)** using only literary language that does not take into account colloquial language.

**d)** free variation of how words are spelled and sound.

**Answer: b**

## Task 8

**Basic level (maximum 1 point)**

**Field of science:** Literature, slavic

Building a series of inferences on a given topic and aiming for logical conclusions are characteristic features of… .

**a)** description

**b)** reasoning

**c)** narration

**d)** narration with elements of description

**Answer: b**

## Task 9

**Basic level (maximum 1 point)**

**Field of science:** Literature, slavic

A typical conflict in romantic works is the confrontation of ...

**a)** two generations

**b)** two social groups

**c)** two families

**d)** an individual and a crowd

**Answer: d**

## Task 10

**Basic level (maximum 1 point)**

**Field of science:** Literature, slavic

Which answer correctly arranges literary movements chronologically?

**a)** romanticism, modernism, realism

**b)** romanticism, realism, modernism

**c)** realism, modernism, romanticism

**d)** modernism, realism, romanticism

**Answer: b**

## Task 11

**Basic level (maximum 1 point)**

**Field of science:** Literature, slavic

Which famous Russian artist painted the picture "Bogatyrs"?

**a)** I. Repin

**b)** V. Surikov

**c)** V. Vasnetsov

**d)** V. Perov

**Answer: c**

## Task 12

**Basic level (maximum 1 point)**

**Field of science:** Literary theory & criticism

Linguistic units of a literary text must be understandable to the reader because in this case …

**a)** the text preserves its artistic value.

**b)** the text is becoming outdated.

**c)** the text may lose its credibility.

**d)** otherwise, this text cannot be considered as a literary one

**Answer: a**

## Task 13

**Basic level (maximum 1 point)**

**Field of science:** Literary theory & criticism

A literary archetype is …

**a)** an artistic double of the author

**b)** a lyrical hero

**c)** a generic image of the hero

**d)** a type of character

**Answer: c**

## Task 14

**Basic level (maximum 1 point)**

**Field of science:** Literary theory & criticism

Marmeladov from F.M. Dostoevsky's novel "Crime and Punishment" is an example of the following literary archetype:

**a)** a quirky man

**b)** a little man

**c)** a rogue

**d)** a superfluous man

**Answer: b**

## Task 15

**Basic level (maximum 1 point)**

**Field of science:** Literary theory & criticism

… is an artistic and philosophical movement that emerged in the late 19th – early 20th centuries, characterized by a break from tradition and a search for new forms of expression.

**a)** Mass culture

**b)** Working-class culture

**c)** Modernism

**d)** Romanticism

**Answer: c**

## Task 16

**Basic level (maximum 1 point)**

**Field of science:** Communication

Which of the following is an example of a sociolect?

**a)** the speech of a TV presenter on a federal channel

**b)** teenagers using specific vocabulary in a TikTok chat

**c)** the dialect of people living in Karelia

**d)** official business correspondence between companies

**Answer: b**

## Task 17

**Basic level (maximum 1 point)**

**Field of science:** Communication

Which genre of journalistic writing typically uses a question-and-answer composition?

**a)** chronicle

**b)** essay

**c)** article

**d)** interview

**Answer: d**

## Task 18

**Basic level (maximum 1 point)**

**Field of science:** Communication

In Slavic pagan mythology, Perun is …

**a)** the deity of summer

**b)** the god of the sun and fertility

**c)** the patron of cattle and cattle breeders

**d)** the god of thunder

**Answer: d**

## Task 19

**Basic level (maximum 1 point)**

**Field of science:** Communication

Subcultures of different nationalities are called …

**a)** age

**b)** ethnic

**c)** corporate

**d)** religious

**Answer: b**

## Task 20

**Basic level (maximum 1 point)**

**Field of science:** Communication

In the context of intercultural communication theory, color perception is …

**a)** independent of culture

**b)** congenital

**c)** culturally determined

**d)** caused by the work of the left hemisphere of the brain

**Answer: c**

## Task 21

**Basic level (maximum 1 point)**

**Field of science:** Cultural studies

Which example illustrates the process of self-identification?

**a)** A girl who doesn't know her roots and isn't interested in her culture.

**b)** Foreign students who come to study in another country quickly adapt to the new cultural environment and begin to follow local traditions.

**c)** An emigrant who strives to be like the people of another culture around him to become part of society.

**d)** A family living in a metropolis that considers itself part of a certain ethnic group and is proud of its traditions.

**Answer: d**

## Task 22

**Basic level (maximum 1 point)**

**Field of science:** Cultural studies

Which factors primarily determine the stylistic features of a text?

**a)** functional style and the target audience

**b)** the history of the text development

**c)** issues related to the publicistic style development

**d)** modern issues of expressive syntax

**Answer: a**

## Task 23

**Basic level (maximum 1 point)**

**Field of science:** Cultural studies

Which of the following is a romantic literary work?

**a)** An elegy

**b)** An ode

**c)** An epigram

**d)** A farce

**Answer: a**

## Task 24

**Basic level (maximum 1 point)**

**Field of science:** Cultural studies

Which of the following movements is characterized by a break with tradition?

**a)** realism

**b)** classicism

**c)** modernism

**d)** naturalism

**Answer: c**

# Task 25

**Basic level (maximum 1 point)**

**Field of science:** Cultural studies

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The design of this object is an example of a traditional Russian painting style called …

**a)** Khokhloma painting

**b)** Mezen painting

**c)** Gorodets painting

**d)** Gzhel painting

**Answer: d**

## Task 26

**Intermediate level (maximum 3 points)**

**Field of science:** Russian Language Studies and other languages in Russia

Which THREE sentences contain examples of adjunction?

**a)** The girls laughed loudly.

**b)** The book was lying on the table.

**c)** Peter nodded silently and turned to the window.

**d)** Smiling, the father left the room.

**e)** The grandfather told his granddaughter fairy tales.

**f)** The owner of the house watched the guests.

**Answer: a, c, d**

## Task 27

**Intermediate level (maximum 3 points)**

**Field of science:** Russian Language Studies and other languages in Russia

Which THREE of the following elements constitute the stylistic coloring of a linguistic unit?

**a)** shades of meaning additional to the core nominative meaning

**b)** expressive properties of a unit

**c)** functional properties of a unit

**d)** history of a linguistic unit

**e)** specific features to take into account while translating a linguistic unit into a foreign language

**f)** specific features to take into account while using linguistic units in one paragraph

**Answer: a, b, c**

## Task 28

**Intermediate level (maximum 3 points)**

**Field of science:** Language & linguistics, comparative studies

Which THREE languages are agglutinative?

**a)** Hungarian
**b)** Latin
**c)** Tatar
**d)** Norwegian
**e)** Kazakh
**f)** Chinese

**Answer: a, c, e**

## Task 29

**Intermediate level (maximum 3 points)**

**Field of science:** Language & linguistics, comparative studies

Which THREE grammatical categories characterize nouns in the Russian language?

**a)** gender
**b)** number
**c)** time
**d)** voice (active, passive)
**e)** aspect
**f)** case

**Answer: a, b, f**

## Task 30

**Intermediate level (maximum 3 points)**

**Field of science:** Language & linguistics, comparative studies

Select THREE scientific schools in the field of linguistics which made a significant contribution to the development of phonology as an independent level of language and developed the theory of the phoneme.

**a)** The Kazan Linguistic School

**b)** The Linguistic Circle of Copenhagen

**c)** The Moscow Phonological School

**d)** The Leningrad Phonological School

**e)** The Leiden School

**Answer: a, c, d**

## Task 31

**Intermediate level (maximum 3 points)**

**Field of science:** Literature, slavic

Which THREE themes are explored by I. A. Bunin in his short story “The Gentleman from San Francisco”?

**a)** the relationship between a human and nature

**b)** memory

**c)** false life values

**d)** loneliness in the modern world

**e)** rebellion

**f)** social contradictions

**Answer: c, d, f**

## Task 32

**Intermediate level (maximum 3 points)**

**Field of science:** Literature, slavic

Which THREE characters appear in M. Gorky’s short story “Old Izergil”?

**a)** Bela

**b)** Arkadek

**c)** Azamat

**d)** Larra

**e)** Kazbich

**f)** Danko

**Answer: b, d, f**

## Task 33

**Intermediate level (maximum 3 points)**

**Field of science:** Literature, slavic

Which THREE of the following pairs correctly match a painting with its artist?

**a)** "Lace Maker" - A. Venetsianov

**b)** "Lace Maker" - V. Tropinin

**c)** "In the Ploughed Field: Spring" - V. Serov

**d)** "In the Ploughed Field: Spring" - A. Venetsianov

**e)** "Girl with Peaches" - V. Tropinin

**f)** "Girl with Peaches" - V. Serov

**Answer: b, d, f**

## Task 34

**Intermediate level (maximum 3 points)**

**Field of science:** Literary theory & criticism

Which of the following are names of literary genres? Select all that apply:

**a)** sonnet

**b)** scenery

**c)** comedy

**d)** genre scene

**e)** portrait

**f)** epic

**Answer: a, c, f**

## Task 35

**Intermediate level (maximum 3 points)**

**Field of science:** Literary theory & criticism

What is the subject matter of a work of art in literature conveyed through?

Choose THREE correct answers.

**a)** its composition

**b)** its theme

**c)** its episodes

**d)** the problem discussed

**e)** its plot

**f)** its idea

**Answer: b, d, f**

## Task 36

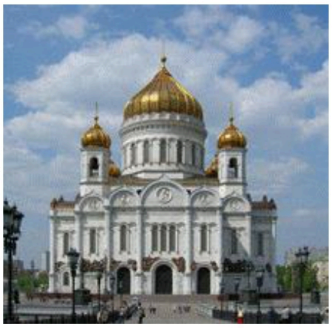
**Intermediate level (maximum 3 points)**

**Field of science:** Literary theory & criticism

a)



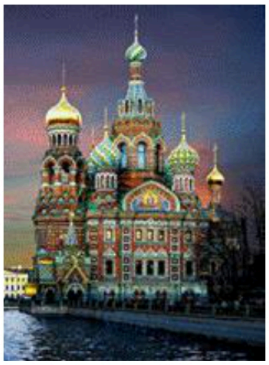
b)



c)



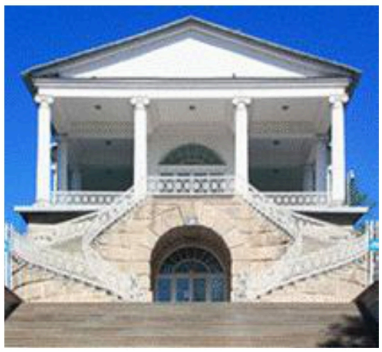
d)



e)



f)



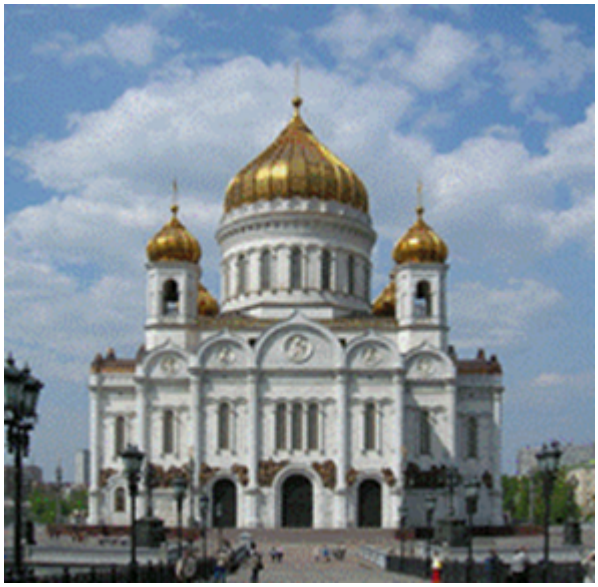
Which THREE of the following buildings were constructed in the Russian-Byzantine style?

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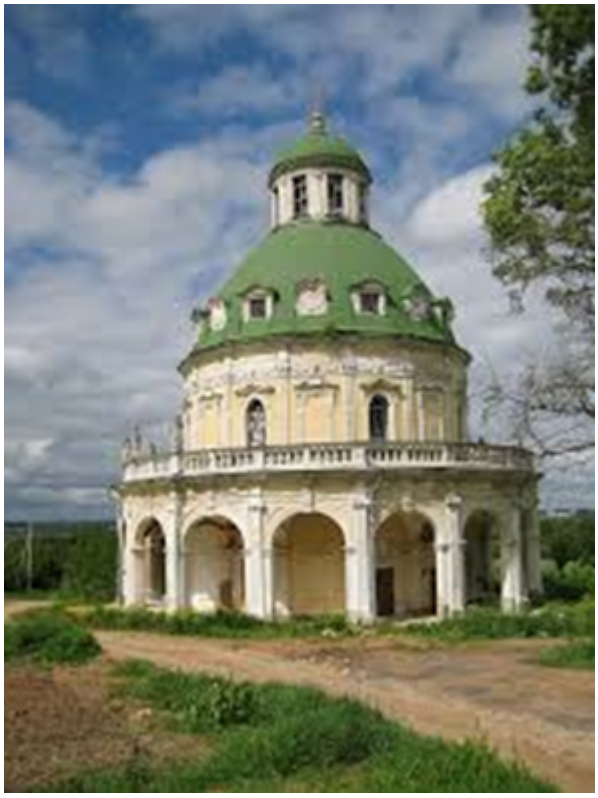
**a)**



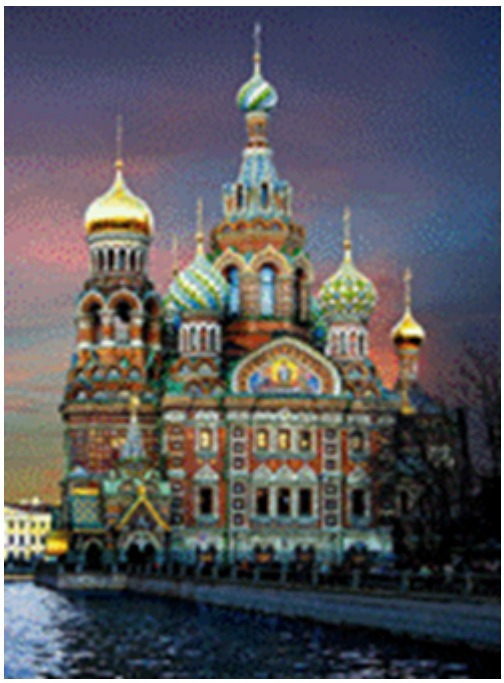
**b)**



**c)**



**d)**



**e)**



**f)**



**Answer: b, d, e**

## Task 37

**Intermediate level (maximum 3 points)**

**Field of science:** Communication

THREE distinctive features of the publicistic style are ...

**a)** evaluativity

**b)** appeal

**c)** impact on the addressee

**d)** simple language

**e)** abundance of incomplete sentences

**f)** absence of complex sentences

**Answer: a, b, c**

## Task 38

**Intermediate level (maximum 3 points)**

**Field of science:** Communication

Which of the following are features of a journalistic text?

Choose THREE correct answers.

**a)** being easily accessible and designed for mass audience

**b)** relevance and topicality of the issues discussed

**c)** rejection of figurative and expressive means

**d)** complete absence of the author's position and subjectivity

**e)** use of only official, business, clerical vocabulary

**f)** use of evaluative vocabulary and means of producing an emotional impact

**Answer: a, b, f**

## Task 39

**Intermediate level (maximum 3 points)**

**Field of science:** Cultural studies

Which of the following characterizes elite culture?

Choose THREE correct answers.

**a)** high content complexity

**b)** targeting a narrow circle of connoisseurs

**c)** democracy

**d)** extensive advertising campaign

**e)** conformity with refined tastes

**f)** the author's boundless self-expression

**Answer: a, b, e**

## Task 40

**Intermediate level (maximum 3 points)**

**Field of science:** Cultural studies

a)



b)



c)



d)



e)



f)



Which THREE paintings were created by K. Korovin?

**a)**



b)



c)



d)



e)



f)



**Answer: b, c, e**

# Task 41

**Advanced level (maximum 10 points)**

**Field of science:** Language & linguistics, comparative studies

Explain the concepts of norm and usage, which are used in philological research, and indicate their main difference; provide examples to support your answer (recommended character count: 700-800).

Note: The reasoning will be taken into account in the assessment; therefore, providing only a short answer is not sufficient.

**Answer:** *Norm – rules of using speech means in a certain period of development of literary language, i.e. rules of pronunciation, word usage, use of traditionally established grammatical, stylistic and other language means accepted in social and linguistic practice. For example, unchangeable forms of possessive pronouns of the 3rd person (his, her, their).*
*Usage is the actual use of language in everyday speech by native speakers, reflecting real language practice, including variability and changes. For example, the use of forms such as theirs, his in colloquial speech.*
*Key difference: the norm is a prescriptive ideal, fixed by dictionaries and grammars, while usage is a descriptive reality, recording a living, often changing speech practice. The norm strives for stability, usage demonstrates the dynamics of language (696 characters).*

**Assessment criteria**

Criterion 1: Criterion 1: Subject matter knowledge: terms, conceptual framework, theoretical foundations. 4 points: Key concepts/terms are defined fully, accurately, and without errors. AND/OR The contestant demonstrated a deep understanding of basic theories, principles, and patterns. 3 points: Key concepts/terms are defined mostly correctly. One minor inaccuracy in a definition is acceptable. AND/OR Basic theories, principles, and patterns are presented correctly, but the details may be incomplete or the wording might contain a minor inaccuracy. 2 points: Definitions of concepts/terms contain inaccuracies, or one of the definitions contains significant errors or is superficial. AND/OR The essence of the theories is conveyed generally correctly, but there are errors while discussing key aspects/the answer lacks significant information. 1 point: Definitions of concepts/terms are extremely superficial, contain significant errors or are not provided. AND/OR Knowledge of theoretical foundations is weak and not profound. 0 points: Definitions are either missing or completely incorrect. AND/OR The contestant fails to demonstrate understanding of basic theories, principles, patterns. — 0–4 points

Criterion 2: Criterion 2. Breadth of outlook: facts, examples, argumentation 3 points: The contestant provides diverse, precise, relevant facts and examples. The examples illustrate the theory well. Erudition and independent thinking while discussing the topic are clearly manifested. 2 points: The contestant provides relevant facts/examples, but these may be not sufficient. The examples support the theory, but the explanation of their relevance is superficial or insufficiently detailed. 1 point: Facts and examples are isolated, irrelevant, contain errors or are missing. Understanding of the topic is narrow and incomplete. 0

points: Facts and examples are missing or completely irrelevant to the topic. Outlook is not demonstrated. The answer is based on everyday ideas or does not correspond to the topic. — 0–3 points

Criterion 3: Criterion 3. English language proficiency: clarity, understandability, accuracy 3 points: The ideas are expressed clearly and logically. The answer is structured. A clear train of thought is traced. The vocabulary and grammar used are relevant. There are no significant speech/grammatical errors that impede understanding. 2 points: The main idea is clear, but there may be minor logical errors or poor wording, the clear flow of thought might be disrupted. There are isolated speech or grammatical errors, inaccuracies in word usage. 1 point: The idea is expressed unclearly, confusingly. The logic of the presentation is disrupted, the structure is poor or completely non-existent. Comprehension is impeded. Numerous speech and/or grammatical errors, serious lexical errors distort the meaning significantly or impede understanding. 0 points: The text is almost incomprehensible or completely disorganized. The main idea is not clear. Errors are systemic, making communication impossible or extremely difficult. — 0–3 points

## Task 42

**Advanced level (maximum 10 points)**

**Field of science:** Literature, slavic

A.P. Chekhov "Fat and Thin". Read the text and perform a philological analysis based on the questions given after the text. Your analysis should be presented as a coherent text (recommended answer length – 1000 characters).

A.P. Chekhov "Fat and Thin"

“Well, how are you doing my friend?” the fat man asked, looking enthusiastically at his friend. “Are you in the service? What grade have you reached?”

“I am, dear boy! I have been a collegiate assessor for the last two years and I have the Stanislav. The salary is poor, but that’s no great matter! The wife gives music lessons, and I go in for carving wooden cigarette cases in a private way. Capital cigarette cases! I sell them for a rouble each. If any one takes ten or more I make a reduction of course. We get along somehow. I served as a clerk, you know, and now I have been transferred here as a head clerk in the same department. I am going to serve here. And what about you? I bet you are a civil councillor by now? Eh?”

“No dear boy, go higher than that,” said the fat man. “I have risen to privy councillor already . . . I have two stars.”

The thin man turned pale and rigid all at once, but soon his face twisted in all directions in the broadest smile; it seemed as though sparks were flashing from his face and eyes. He squirmed, he doubled together, crumpled up. . . . His portmanteaus, bundles and cardboard boxes seemed to shrink and crumple up too. . . . His wife’s long chin grew longer still; Nafanail drew himself up to attention and fastened all the buttons of his uniform.

“Your Excellency, I . . . delighted! The friend, one may say, of childhood and to have turned into such a great man! He—he!”

“Come, come!” the fat man frowned. “What’s this tone for? You and I were friends as boys, and there is no need of this official obsequiousness!”

“Merciful heavens, your Excellency! What are you saying. . . ?” sniggered the thin man, wriggling more than ever. “Your Excellency’s gracious attention is like refreshing manna. . . . This, your Excellency, is my son Nafanail, . . . my wife Luise, a Lutheran in a certain sense.”

The fat man was about to make some protest, but the face of the thin man wore an expression of such reverence, sugariness, and mawkish respectfulness that the privy councillor was sickened. He turned away from the thin man, giving him his hand at parting.

The thin man pressed three fingers, bowed his whole body and sniggered like a Chinaman: “He—he—he!” His wife smiled. Nafanail scraped with his foot and dropped his cap. All three were agreeably overwhelmed.

**Questions:**

1. Define the theme of this passage.

2. Define the genre of A.P. Chekhov's “Fat and Thin”.

3. What literary movement is this piece by A.P. Chekhov an example of?

4. Find stylistic devices and expressive means in this passage and provide examples.

5. Identify the type of discourse represented by this passage (narration, description, or argumentation). Justify your answer.

6. Which character do you have fellow feelings for? Justify your answer.

7. Can the “thin man” in Chekhov’s story be considered an example of the “little man” literary type? Name works of Russian literature in which the “little man” appears.

**Note:** The reasoning will be taken into account in the assessment; therefore, providing only a short answer is not sufficient.

**Answer:** The text recounts a meeting between two childhood friends who have not seen each other for many years. It is a satirical story written in the tradition of critical realism.

The text employs antithesis (the fat man and the thin man), personification (“his portmanteaus, bundles, and cardboard boxes seemed to shrink and crumple up too”), metaphor (“the face of the thin man wore an expression of such reverence, sugariness, and mawkish respectfulness”), hyperbole (“his wife’s long chin grew longer still”; “the privy councillor was sickened”), and grotesque imagery (“He squirmed, doubled himself up, and crumpled”). This passage is an example of narration, as the author predominantly uses past-tense verbs (“asked,” “turned pale,” “frowned,” etc.) to convey a sequence of actions.

I sympathize with the fat man because he is genuinely happy to meet his old friend, does not attach importance to social rank, and dislikes being treated with excessive deference.

The thin man embodies some of the characteristics of the **“little man”** literary type: he is a minor official, earns a modest salary, and is accustomed to currying favor with his superiors. However, he also has some distinctive features. In the works of Gogol and Dostoevsky, the “little man” typically evokes pity and sympathy, whereas Chekhov portrays the thin man satirically. The traditional “little man” is generally presented as a victim of the social system, while Chekhov’s character voluntarily fawns over his childhood friend. Moreover, the fate of the traditional “little man” is often tragic, whereas Chekhov’s story has no tragic ending. Thus, the thin man can be regarded as a parodic version of the “little man.” Chekhov does not sympathize with him but instead ridicules his servile mentality, deference to rank, and voluntary self-abasement.

The literary type of the “little man” is represented in A. S. Pushkin’s “The Stationmaster”, N. V. Gogol’s “The Overcoat”, A. P. Chekhov’s “The Man in a Case”, and A. I. Kuprin’s “The Garnet Bracelet”, among other works.

**Assessment criteria**

Criterion 1: Mastery of the subject: terms, conceptual apparatus, theoretical foundations (genre, literary direction defined, expressive means found, type of speech defined) — 0–4 points

Criterion 2: Breadth of outlook: facts, examples, argumentation (at least two works are named) — 0–3 points

Criterion 3: Language proficiency: clarity, accessibility, accuracy — 0–3 points

## Task 43

**Advanced level (maximum 10 points)**

**Field of science:** Cultural studies



Look at the reproduction of the painting by the famous Russian artist Boris Kustodiev "Maslenitsa" and answer the questions that follow in writing. Your text should be coherent; recommended length-1000 characters.

Questions:

What is depicted in the painting?

Specify the genre of the painting: is it a portrait, a landscape or a still life painting? Justify your choice.

Which colors did the artist use and why?

What mood does the image convey?

**Note:** The reasoning will be taken into account in the assessment; therefore, providing only a short answer is not sufficient.

**Answer:** Kustodiev's painting depicts Maslenitsa, the traditional Russian Shrovetide festival. In the foreground, towering snowdrifts and frost-covered trees frame a colourful crowd of elegantly dressed townspeople riding in decorated horse-drawn sleighs. Despite the deep snow and wintry cold, the first

signs of approaching spring can already be felt in the air. The powerful horses are adorned with ribbons and bells. Through his masterful rendering of movement, Kustodiev conveys the festive bustle of the scene and imbues the canvas with a sense of exuberant joy and unrestrained merriment.
In the background, one can see decorated buildings, a carousel, and a spacious square, the center of the folk festival. The sky shimmers with all the shades of sunset.
The painting masterfully uses contrasts of light and shadow, as well as theatrical and decorative techniques, lending the scene a particularly spectacular quality. The artist makes the chilly winter palette come alive using bright, vibrant color accents.
This work is classified as a genre painting with landscape elements, as the people and their festive life are in the focus of attention, while nature merely provides the backdrop. The painting conveys a unique festive mood and testifies to the artist's boundless love for the Russian people and their authentic traditions.

**Assessment criteria**

Criterion 1: terms, conceptual framework, theoretical foundations (the genre of the painting is indicated – landscape, the subject of the description is indicated – autumn forest, the terms are used – in the foreground, in the background, the colors are listed, there is an indication of the mood conveyed by the painting). — 0–4 points

Criterion 2: Breadth of outlook: facts, examples, argumentation (all the main objects depicted in the reproduction of the painting are listed: forest, river, birch trees, field, sky, gold color; 2 examples of the use of paint in the reproduction of the painting are given; there is an argumentation about what mood the painting conveys) — 0–3 points

Criterion 3: English language proficiency: clarity, understandability, accuracy — 0–3 points

## Task 44

*For the oral-response section, the participant must choose one of the three tasks numbered 44, 45, and 46.*

**Oral-response task (maximum 2 points)**

**Field of science:** Language & linguistics, comparative studies

Give an extended response of up to two minutes on the following topic:

How do media (TV, online publications) influence usage? Can mistakes or careless speech in the media contribute to the violation of the norm? Provide arguments and give examples to support your position.

**Answer:** Mass media have a significant influence on linguistic usage – the generally accepted practice of using a language. This influence is twofold: the media can both support codified norms and contribute to their change.
Firstly, central TV channels and radio stations serve as the main channel for disseminating standardized speech. Professional announcers demonstrate exemplary adherence to orthoepic and accentological norms. This contributes to the preservation of traditional norms in public usage.

Secondly, the media, especially Internet platforms, are the main source of dissemination of new vocabulary. They actively introduce neologisms and borrowings into speech circulation. The media directly influence the formation of the active vocabulary of speakers, accelerating the transition of new words from passive to common usage and further to normative recognition.
However, systematic errors in the speech of journalists and bloggers pose a threat to the language norm. Violations of grammatical, accentual and lexical norms in authoritative sources lead to their consolidation in the mass consciousness of native speakers. The high frequency of such errors contributes to their consolidation in usage, especially among the younger generation, creating variability and weakening the position of the codified norm.
Thus, the media perform a contradictory function: on the one hand, they consolidate the norm, on the other hand, they serve as a mechanism for language changes. Thus, mass errors are capable of transforming the usage and changing the normative system. This is related to the concept of the two-way dependence of language evolution, described by E.D. Polivanov.

**Assessment criteria**

Criterion 1: Subject-specific knowledge (terminology, conceptual framework, and theoretical foundations).

Criterion 2: Breadth of knowledge (relevant facts, illustrative examples, and the integration of theory and practice).

## Task 45

**Oral-response task (maximum 2 points)**

**Field of science:** Literature, slavic

Give an extended response of up to two minutes on the following topic: “Ideological-thematic and plot-compositional features of “Fat and Thin” by A.P. Chekhov’s”. Provide arguments and examples to support your position.

**Answer:** A. P. Chekhov’s short story *Fat and Thin* is a striking example of his satirical prose, addressing significant social issues with remarkable concision. Its central themes are excessive deference to rank and a servile mentality. Chekhov ridicules the tendency of people of lower social standing to grovel before their superiors, thereby sacrificing their self-respect. The story also explores social inequality, insincerity, and hypocrisy. Chekhov demonstrates how excessive reverence for rank distorts human relationships: even friendship cannot withstand the test of social status.
The plot centres on a chance encounter between two former schoolmates, Porfiry (“the thin man”) and Mikhail (“the fat man”). Initially, they are delighted to see each other. However, when the thin man learns that his old friend has attained the high rank of Privy Councillor, his behaviour changes abruptly: he becomes obsequious and self-abasing and begins addressing Mikhail as “Your Excellency.”
The story’s composition can be divided into several parts. The exposition presents the meeting at the railway station and the friends’ joyful recognition of each other. The conversation about their lives sets the action in motion. The climax occurs when the thin man discovers the fat man’s official rank. In the

denouement, the thin man and his family behave with humiliating servility, while the fat man becomes disgusted by their conduct.
The system of characters is structured around contrast, particularly the opposition between the self-assured fat man and the pathetic, obsequious thin man. In this brief story, Chekhov masterfully exposes the degradation of the individual under the pressure of social conventions. He shows how excessive deference to rank destroys genuine human feeling.

**Assessment criteria**

Criterion 1: Subject-specific knowledge (terminology, conceptual framework, and theoretical foundations).

Criterion 2: Breadth of knowledge (relevant facts, illustrative examples, and the integration of theory and practice).

## Task 46

**Oral-response task (maximum 2 points)**

**Field of science:** Cultural studies

Talk about the urban landscape as a genre of painting. Name the distinctive features of this genre and give examples of paintings. What role do works of Russian artists play in understanding Russian culture?

**Answer:** An urban landscape is a type of landscape, where images of the city become the main focus of attention. Urban landscapes depict buildings, streets, and architectural structures. There are various types, including street, architectural, industrial, park, and others. An urban landscape conveys the atmosphere of the time, the mood and rhythm of urban life, the spirit of the era, and the balance between nature and the city. Light and shadow, as well as various styles and techniques, are used to convey the dynamism and scale of the urban environment. It is important to combine lyrical perception with documentary precision. Famous urban landscapes by artists such as K. Korovin's "Northern Idyll," F. Alekseev's "Red Square in Moscow," M. Vorobyov's "Peter and Paul Fortress," and others. Russian artists help us understand and love Russian culture, reveal the beauty of Russian cities from different eras, and help us connect the past with the present.

**Assessment criteria**

Criterion 1: Subject-specific knowledge (terminology, conceptual framework, and theoretical foundations).

Criterion 2: Breadth of knowledge (relevant facts, illustrative examples, and the integration of theory and practice).